in the phase when he would flare up, be reactive—much more than was good for him. But, you see him now—all he wants to do is work." Not only did the performer have a successful multi-city tour in the US, Raftaar recently crooned '3 Ka Dream', a spirited track to boost the men in blue for the ICC Men's Cricket World Cup.

Having worked his way up through the Hindi, Punjabi and Haryanvi music world, collaborated with Yo Yo Honey Singh in the Mafia Mundeer crew and RDB's Manj Musik, Raftaar broke into Bollywood with tracks like 'Dhaakad' (from the movie *Dangal*) and a remake of 'Haseeno Ka Deewana' (for *Kaabil*). The rapper is now reclaiming familiar terrain by collaborating with leading Punjabi singer, Parmish Verma, for a song that will release later this year.

Not one to be confined by geographical or linguistic boundaries, the 33-year-old, Thiruvananthapuram-born, Delhi-bred rapper is also joining hands with Indian-American DJ-producer KSHMR for an electric club banger, 'Legacy', the third track from KSHMR's much-awaited Indian hip-hop album *Karam*.

As if this weren't enough, the man of many talents is also focusing, as an entrepreneur, on his label Kalamkaar, which he co-founded with Khanna in 2019. Speaking about his different avatars, Raftaar says, "Once I started rapping, I used that platform to showcase my other talents. I am grateful that the hard work has paid off and I have managed to make a little space in people's hearts."

It has also got him rubbing people the wrong way, but that's something the singer brushes off. "I'm a very blunt guy," he says. "But now I don't get angry anymore. I fail to understand why people are dissing each other right now. *Depressed ho? Dukhi ho?* Kalamkaar *ke gaane suno na*," he signs off. ■

Aarti Kapur Singh

MUSIC

Season's Specials

Some fresh-out-of-the-oven releases for your next winter deep listening sesh







MULTANI MITTI, *DRV and Boyblanck*

Fresh off the success of his single 'Farak Nahin Padhta'—you may have heard it in the OTT show *Farzi*—DRV teams up with fellow rapper Boyblanck for an album of North Indian trap focused on their shared ancestral Multani heritage. Over reverb-drenched kicks and overdriven synths, the young duo trade bars full of history, mythology and self-aggrandising braggadocio. A particular highlight is 'Tarakkiyan', its Punjabi folk vocals cutting their way through DRV and Boyblanck's murky trap beats.

DEV NAGRI AUR MAIN
Dakait x Sez On The Beat

Beatmaker Sez On The Beat has crafted some of India's biggest rap hits—including the 2015 Divine and Naezy collab 'Mere Gully Mein'—on his way to becoming Indian hip-hop's most coveted producer. Now he teams up with Uttarakhand's Dakait for *Dev Nagri Aur Main*, an album that pays tribute to the rapper's home state. Blending global hip-hop and trap with Uttarakhandi folk music, Dakait raps about his cultural roots and self-discovery journey. Keep an ear out for features from Raga, Yungsta and 2FISTD, as well as a Garhwali rap verse by Aniket Raturi.

THE GROUND BENEATH HER FEET
Sandunes

For years, Sanaya Ardeshir—aka Sandunes—has been at the forefront of India's electronic underground, thanks to her eclectic, forward-thinking compositions that bring her roots in classical piano and jazz in conversation with contemporary dance music. Written during the lockdown, her third album explores themes of migration, identity and womanhood through songs that blend jazz, soul, synth-pop and avant-garde electronica.



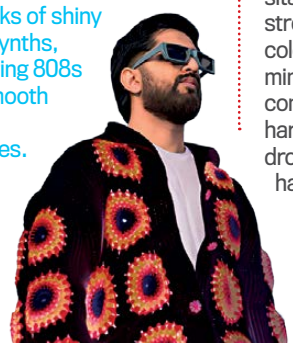


INTIHA
Ali Sethi x Nicolas Jaar

On paper, ghazal revivalist Ali Sethi and Chilean-American experimental producer Nicolas Jaar seem like odd collaborators, their music ensconced in dramatically different sounds and cultural contexts. But they share a love for intuitive improvisation, which they deploy to great effect on *Intiha*. The duo rework Jaar's fluid ambient soundscapes from his 2020 album *Telas* into a timeless backdrop for Sethi's raw, full-throated vocals, as he sings about love, loss and longing.

TURBO
Talal Qureshi

Pakistani producer and composer Talal Qureshi has been making waves with his signature blend of downtempo electronica and traditional Pakistani music since 2007. His latest album *Turbo* brings together collaborators from across the South Asian music landscape—Pakistani indie trailblazers like Zaw Ali and Natasha Noorani, Indian rapper Yashraj and Indian classical-meets-R&B singer Mitika Kanwar—for 12 tracks of shiny neon synths, stuttering 808s and smooth vocal melodies.



CHAPTER I: FOREVER, FOR NOW
Anoushka Shankar

Last summer, Anoushka Shankar was spending a lazy afternoon in the garden, strumming her sitar as her two sons dozed in the sun. A memory surfaced, an old Carnatic lullaby that her mother and grandmother once sung to her. Her latest four-track EP—the first in a planned trilogy of 'mini-albums'—is all about that moment. Shankar's sitar paints in bold strokes of emotional colour over ambient, minimal soundscapes consisting of harmonium bass drones and glass harmonicas.

by Bhanuj Kappal